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At Girnar the message was, in its full form, beautifully and compactly laid out on the eastern side of a single large rock. This is located in the suburbs of Junagadh city in Gujarat. The hand that inscribed all fourteen edicts was likely to have been the same, the characters clearly and decisively cut, more or less uniform in size. The rock itself is spectacular and on ancient visitors its impact may have been as considerable as it is in our time. While no ancient description of it has survived, the response of a visitor in 1822 seems strikingly well worded:

> Let me describe what to the antiquary will appear the noblest monument of Saurashtra, a monument speaking in an unknown tongue of other times . . . The memorial in question, and evidently of some great conqueror is a huge hemispherical mass of dark granite, which, like a wart upon the body, has protruded through the crust of mother earth, without fissure or inequality, and which, by the aid of the 'iron pen,' has been converted into a book. The measurement of its arc is nearly ninety feet; its surface is divided into compartments or parallelograms, within which are inscriptions in the usual antique character. Two of these cartouches I had copied, by my old Guru, with the most scrupulous fidelity, and a portion of a third, where the characters varied . . . I may well call it a book; for the rock is covered with these characters, so uniform in execution, that we may safely pronounce all those of the most ancient class, which I designate the 'Pandu character,' to be the work of one man.[1]

The writer is Lieutenant-Colonel James Tod, famous Rajasthan annalist and army antiquarian of the East India Company. His reaction to Girnar was written before the Brahmi script had been deciphered. His account is arresting for the recognition that the edict is both monument and inscription, an ancient rock transformed to a monument by the writing on it.[2]